# Madhu Poonacha

**Application for Head of Operations, DataLab | Cover letter and executive pages for the DataLab Control Tower**

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**The Hiring Team, Protege**
Re: Head of Operations, DataLab

Dear Protege hiring team,

I want to start with a plain fact: **I live in Bengaluru, India.** Some listings describe this role as US-based remote, so I would rather ask than assume. **Are you open to hiring this role from India?** I have worked US-aligned hours for 20+ years, including a two-year on-site assignment in Seattle, and I am ready to run my day on US time. If the role has to sit in the US, I understand completely, and I would still be grateful for your view of the proposal that comes with this letter.

Here is why I think the role is worth a conversation. Protege exists because access to the right training data is slow, expensive and often fails. That promise is only as strong as the DataLab's own speed and trust. I read the job as turning a talented team handling one-off requests into a repeatable engine: one door for demand, the highest-value work chosen in the open, privacy and quality gates that are fast but unskippable, and a CEO who sees impact without chasing it. I have spent 20+ years doing that in customer-facing technology delivery, rather than under a chief-of-staff title:

- **Built the evaluation discipline.** A 150-case gold-standard set, a monthly expert audit of 150+ AI outputs and calibration loops lifted measured correctness from **72% to 93%**, with 94% reviewer consensus.
- **Kept the metrics honest.** In an Intercom Fin rollout I separated raw deflection (~60%) from confirmed resolution (~40% of deflected cases), so no headline number overstated results.
- **Turned repeat requests into tooling.** A role-controlled correction tool built with Engineering cut turnaround from **7 business days to 10 minutes** and SQL requests to Engineering by 85%.
- **Ran scarce expertise as a service.** A 15-person, 24/5 specialist center grew into close to **$1M in annualized billable work**, inside a 70+ person organization (100+ counting partner pods) and a ~$2.5M budget.

Rather than only describe how I would run DataLab, I built a working model of it. The **DataLab Control Tower** delivered with this application, with the executive pages that follow) runs the same 12 weeks of demand through ad hoc and structured operations side by side. At 2x demand, the structured model ships **63 requests against 17**, with a **7-day median cycle time against 28**. The data is synthetic and built only from your public posting. I expect to be wrong about parts of how DataLab really works, and I would validate that in the first week.

Two answers would help me most: **whether you are open to this role from India**, and **whether the proposal matches the problems you see.** If yes, I would welcome 30 minutes to walk you through the Control Tower. If not, thank you for the candor, and I wish you well.

Sincerely,
**Madhu Poonacha**
+91 99456 99262 | madhu.poonacha5@gmail.com | linkedin.com/in/madhubk

# Executive summary: what DataLab operations has to solve

Built from the public job posting. Where I am inferring, I say so, and I would validate it in the first week of conversations.

### The market problem

AI teams cannot easily get the right training data. The process is slow, expensive and often ends in failure. Protege's platform exists to make that exchange secure, efficient and privacy-centric.

### Protege's own problem (inferred)

Protege sells the fix for slow, costly, failure-prone data access, so its internal delivery speed is the product promise. Every partner request still needs a fit judgment, privacy review, quality validation and delivery. If that runs on informal handoffs, the company becomes what it set out to replace, and because the product is trust, speed cannot cost privacy.

## WHAT THE ROLE HAS TO SOLVE

**Prioritization**
Demand outruns capacity and nobody owns how work is chosen.

**Handoffs**
Work stalls between Data, Product and Engineering at sourcing, privacy review and quality checks.

**Visibility**
Leadership cannot see progress, cost or impact, so the CEO becomes the integration layer.

**Scalability**
The current way of working will not survive 3x volume.

## THE OPERATING SYSTEM IN 90 DAYS: THE LIGHTEST PROCESS THAT REMOVES THE MOST PAIN

### Days 1 to 30: diagnose and earn trust

- Interview the CEO, Data, Product and Engineering leads and one or two partners: what is stuck, what is most valuable, what keeps repeating.
- Trace 5 to 10 recent projects end to end and record where time was lost.
- Put every active and queued request on one shared board.
- Week 2 quick win: the board plus a weekly priorities note.

**Done when:** a one-page diagnosis ranks the top 3 bottlenecks by cost, and all active work is on the board.

### Days 31 to 60: install the lightest system

- One intake template and a visible scoring model; the CEO keeps the final call.
- A work-in-progress limit, a capacity view and a "what we are not doing" list.
- Privacy and quality gates agreed with the security owner: fast and unskippable.
- A weekly 30-minute prioritization meeting and a weekly brief.

**Done when:** every new request enters through one door and gets a first response within 2 business days (target).

### Days 61 to 90: instrument and scale

- A six-metric dashboard that refreshes automatically.
- Automate intake routing, status updates, quality checks and the CEO brief.
- A two-to-three-quarter roadmap with owners and dates.
- Scope the first one or two hires so operator duties do not become permanent.

**Done when:** the CEO gets the brief without asking and the first hire is scoped.

## GUARDRAILS, EACH TIED TO A PROTEGE VALUE

- **Fast lane for urgent, high-value work** so the system never strangles velocity (Go Fast and Grow Fast).
- **An unskippable but quick privacy gate**, because in a data-exchange company trust is the product (Pass the Loved Ones' Test).
- **One named owner for every request and every metric** (Own the Outcome).
- **Named owners at each cross-team handoff**, with blockers surfaced weekly (Deliver Together).
- **A brief written plainly, with a recommendation attached to every decision needed** (Practice Kindness and Candor).
- **Outcome metrics, not activity counts**: deal-linked requests are flagged at intake so influence on revenue is measured the same way every time.

**Direct Link to the tool: https://madhupoonacha5-hub.github.io/protege-control-tower/**

# The DataLab Control Tower: the operating system, simulated

An interactive model (index.html) that runs the same demand through two ways of working. Synthetic data; illustrative numbers.

Both sides face the identical 12-week request stream and the same four shocks: a CEO urgent ask (day 12), PII found in a source dataset (day 25), a researcher out for a week (day 35) and a demand spike of 8 requests (day 45). Capacity is 6 person-days a day, plus 1.5 a day of privacy review.

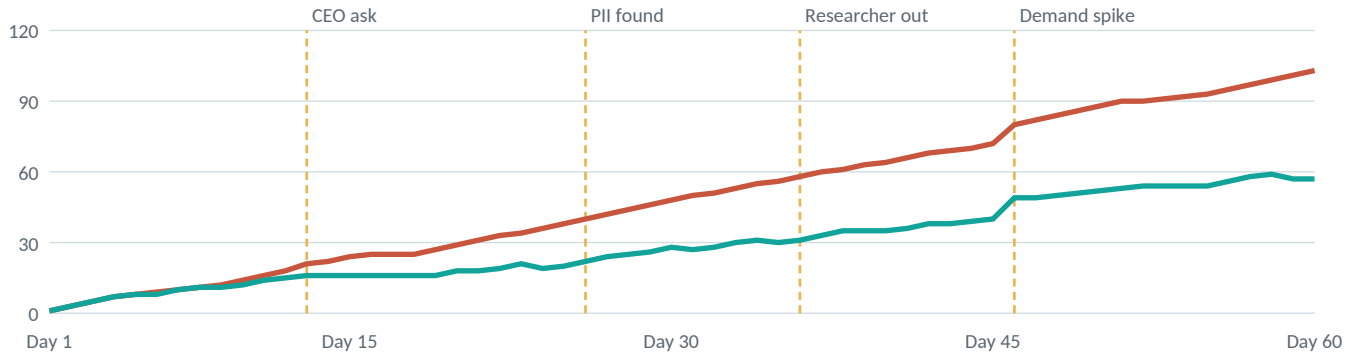
| Mechanism | Ad hoc | Operating system |
|---|---|---|
| **Intake and priority** | Slack and memory; the loudest voice wins. | One front door; a visible score the CEO can overrule. |
| **Work in progress** | Everything starts at once; overhead climbs from 25% to 55%. | A limit of 7, plus a fast lane; overhead 10% through automation. |
| **Privacy review** | Checked last, so PII findings send prepared work back. | An early gate; mitigation is scheduled before prep. |
| **Quality** | Criteria discovered late; 20% of checks fail. | Acceptance criteria set at intake; 7% fail. |

## Results at day 60

| | 1x demand | | 2x demand | | 3x demand | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Ad hoc | Ops system | Ad hoc | Ops system | Ad hoc | Ops system |
| Requests delivered | 25 | **50** | 17 | **63** | 10 | **60** |
| Median cycle time (days) | 13 | **7** | 28 | **7** | 24 | **8** |
| Delivered on time | 36% | **86%** | 24% | **65%** | 10% | **60%** |
| Still open at day 60 | 35 | **10** | 103 | **57** | 156 | **106** |
| Average backlog age (days) | 17.7 | **11.6** | 25.2 | **22.2** | 29 | **27** |
| Deal-linked value shipped (points) | 57 | **130** | 46 | **170** | 16 | **220** |

*Cycle time and on-time rates are measured on delivered items only, so read them with the open count: in the ad hoc model most work never finishes. Rework matters too: at 1x demand, 60% of ad hoc deliveries needed no rework against 92% for the operating system.*

### Open requests over time at 2x demand brick: ad hoc teal: operating system dashed lines: shocks




**Read-out.** At 2x demand the operating system ships **63 requests against 17**, holds the median cycle time to **7 days against 28** and delivers **65% on time against 24%**. At 3x demand no process creates capacity: it still ships 60 against 10, and the weekly brief surfaces the real decision, which is to defer lower-value work or add capacity.

# Why this fits, and how working on US hours would run

Proof from work already done, a plain working model from India, and the questions I would validate first.

| What DataLab needs | What I have done | Result |
|---|---|---|
| **Evaluation and quality standards** | Built a 150-case gold-standard set, a monthly expert audit of 150+ outputs across 80+ issue categories and annotation calibration loops. | Measured correctness 72% to 93%; 94% reviewer consensus. |
| **Metrics that stay honest** | Defined metrics separating raw deflection from confirmed resolution across an Intercom Fin rollout. | ~60% deflection, ~40% of deflected cases confirmed resolved; no overstated headline. |
| **Repeat requests become tooling** | Built a role-controlled correction tool with Engineering. | 7 business days to 10 minutes; SQL requests down 85%; 40+ engineering hours a month recovered. |
| **Scarce expertise as a repeatable service** | Founded a 15-person, 24/5 specialist center and productized its expertise. | Close to $1M in annualized billable services. |
| **Scale, budget and trust** | Governed a 70+ person direct and matrixed organization (100+ with partner pods), a ~$2.5M budget and a ~$22M ARR portfolio. | 90% GRR; gross churn down 8 points; 95%+ CSAT. |
| **Privacy and data governance** | Governed RBAC, data-privacy and data-sovereignty frameworks (GDPR/CCPA) and built ETL pipelines into warehouses (Replicon); S3 and Redshift loading patterns (Zenoti). | Secured sensitive data across global deployments. |
| **US executive partnership** | Two-year on-site assignment in Seattle, working directly with US C-suite stakeholders. | A working bridge between US headquarters and global delivery hubs. |

## WORKING FROM INDIA ON US HOURS

- **Where I am:** Bengaluru, India. I have worked US-aligned hours for 20+ years, including two years on site in Seattle.
- **Coverage I would offer:** 9 am to 5 pm US Eastern is 7:30 pm to 3:30 am IST (6:30 pm to 2:30 am during US daylight time). I can shift toward Pacific hours if the team's center of gravity is there. The exact window is yours to set.
- **Async-first rhythm:** the dashboard and weekly brief are ready before the US workday starts, and every decision needed arrives with a recommendation, so leadership time goes to deciding, not chasing.
- **Live time is protected:** I name what needs a live conversation and hold that overlap, so a time-zone gap never becomes a delay.

## WHAT I WOULD VALIDATE IN THE FIRST WEEK

- Is DataLab mainly a research function, a delivery function or both, and who owns the research agenda versus delivery commitments to partners?
- Where do requests originate today (CEO, go-to-market, partners, researchers), and which stall points cost the most?
- Who owns the privacy and security gate, and how long does it take today?
- What does impact mean for DataLab: pipeline influenced, partner satisfaction, research output, or all three?

**Two questions for you.** Are you open to this role from India? Does the proposal match the problems you see? If the answer to the first is no, I understand and thank you for the candor. If yes, I would welcome 30 minutes to walk through the Control Tower together.